INT. SELFRIDGE CITY - COURT OF THE MAGISTRATE - DAY

A Boho-styled room with plants. A BARITONE VOICE OFF-SCREEN HUMS over a Muzak rendition of 'Iko Iko'. SARA, head bowed, sits in Seiza on a circular RUG. She does a double-take:

SAM, out of formation, squints in confusion, jaw slack, as he stares at a NEAR-DEAD PETUNIA-DAPPLED VINE snaking along the walls from a FLOWER POT on a windowsill.

Sara HISSES Sam's name. *Show some respect!* He snaps out of it.

BARITONE VOICE (O.S.)
(in the Queen's English)
Patch 1429.111 installed!

...says the MAGISTRATE: a white *2001*-style MONOLITH with an ABSTRACT MANDALA and SPEAKER for a face and mouth. The Mandala's sectors ROTATE in alignment as he reads a file.

MAGISTRATE
(bored)
For the charge of algorithmic matchmaking fraud, the Parties — heretofore known as the "Contestants" — consent to the Phenome Gauntlet and acknowledge that (a) each death loop increases the opposing party's threat level; (b) voluntary withdrawal results in relocation to Lovesick Island without dissolution of union; and (c) successful completion shall preserve the union — assuming neither contestant terminates the union upon exposure to the disintegration of the other's curated persona.
(chipper)
Now then! Who would like to enter the "Pat Your Head and Rub Your Belly" gauntlet first?

Sara and Sam exchange glances. Sara moves to speak — Sam HISSES her name. *Don't*.

SARA
Your Majesty, it appears you have a bug.

The mandala's sectors SPIN erratically.

MAGISTRATE
<u>Human Resources! Dispose of Dev Lord 834 at once!</u>

Beat. SCREAMS spill out of of his speaker. Then, the CRUNCHY, SQUELCHY SOUNDS of MEAT GRINDING as the two freeze in horror.

MAGISTRATE
Sara Choudhury. I must say, honesty looks good on you.

SARA
(laying it on thick)
Your Majesty, if I may — in the same spirit of honesty, it would be most efficient to restore our matrimonial harmony expeditiously. It remains, after all, the biggest economic driver in a union's productivity matrix.

MAGISTRATE
Yes! Yes, indeed!

SARA
To that end, I propose Sam go first because he's big and strong and can vanquish all versions of me, especially with his beloved golden shears because he's had a lot more practice in topiary than in showing affection to anyone but his mother.

SAM
Wow. First of all — gross. Sara oughta go 'cause her big brain can pull a fast one on all versions of me, beeline right to the exit so she can go back to obsessing about her career instead of
(beat)
Sir.

Sara and Sam stare daggers at one another. Magistrate's mandala sectors spins as he takes it in the drama before realigning.

MAGISTRATE
I hereby declare Sam to enter the gauntlet first for failing to observe the proper form of address vis-à-vis "Sir"

SARA
I humbly thank—

SAM
(points to the vines)
Serpentinia Petunicus!

SARA MAGISTRATE

What? What?

SAM
(chuckles)
Tongue twister's been prairie-
doggin' my brain this whole time.
(beat)
I know why they're dying!

Sara stiffens. *What's his play?*

MAGISTRATE
(mandala whirring)
Ergo my precious Petunias can be
saved!

Sara deflates. *That's his play.*

SAM
Depends on the vine.

MAGISTRATE
You <u>dare</u> titillate the
Magistrate?!

Sara smirks. *He played himself.* Sam walks over to the windowsill.

SAM
That vine needs to reach the very
top, but can't live without the
cool, sterile, emotionally stunted
air of an A/C unit. But them poor,
sweet, innocent Petunias? They
just wanna soak up some rays. Live
in the *now*. They're stuck.

SARA
(rolls her eyes)
Oh, please, you make it sound like
the "poor" petunias are hostages.
(heated)
The Serpentinia was designed to
need both. It wasn't planted
wrong, it was planted—

SAM
(lifts the pot, smiling)
Small. It needs room to grow.

Beat. Sara softens. Magistrate's Mandala spins WILDLY — his anger rising — and then FREEZES asymmetrically.

MAGISTRATE
(seething)
Was that...a metaphor? For your relationship?! Pray tell, is the pot the holy city of Selfridge itself?!

SAM
(sheepish)
Yes. I mean no. I mean — look, if Sara goes first, I can relocate your baby to an A/C-integrated trellis on the south facade. For free.

SARA
<u>You dick</u>!

MAGISTRATE
Sara, it is!

Sara's rug SLIDES OPEN. She DROPS through the trapdoor into—

A CLEAR BLUE SKY

and FREE-FALLS. Sam peeks over the trapdoor.

SAM
(voice trailing)
You got this, babe!